

# Cause Web Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 30-40 min

|            |         |      |           |
|------------|---------|------|-----------|
| Category   | History | Time | 30-40 min |
| Difficulty | Medium  | ID   | cause-web |

Big idea: Causation is layered and contestable.

## Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Cause Web Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

## Concrete Stimulus Packet

|                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                                                                                                      |
|---------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Cause Web Stimulus A</b>     | Student-facing stimulus 1: A web of causes for a school rule change, historical event, or social movement. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support. | Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.             |
| <b>Cause Web Stimulus B</b>     | Student-facing stimulus 2: Cards sorted into trigger, background condition, actor, and consequence. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.        | Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.                                     |
| <b>Cause Web Reveal / Twist</b> | Student-facing stimulus 3: A debate over whether one cause can be 'the' cause. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.                             | Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Causation is layered and contestable. |

## Actual Lesson Questions

| # | Question for students                                                      |
|---|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | After inspecting Cause Web Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim? |
| 2 | Which exact detail from Cause Web Stimulus A did you use as evidence?      |
| 3 | What did you infer beyond the evidence?                                    |
| 4 | How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?                   |
| 5 | What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?           |
| 6 | How do historians decide which causes matter most?                         |

## Ready-to-Use Examples

- A web of causes for a school rule change, historical event, or social movement.
- Cards sorted into trigger, background condition, actor, and consequence.
- A debate over whether one cause can be 'the' cause.

## Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to History.

## Activity Steps

1. Students create a web of causes.
2. They label causes as long-term, short-term, structural, individual, accidental or ideological.
3. They choose the three most important causes and justify their ranking.
4. Groups compare rankings.

## Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

| What I noticed | What I inferred | Evidence | Confidence |
|----------------|-----------------|----------|------------|
|                |                 |          |            |
|                |                 |          |            |
|                |                 |          |            |

## TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: How do historians decide which causes matter most?
- Are historical events inevitable?
- What is the role of chance in historical knowledge?

## Knowledge Questions

- How do historians decide which causes matter most?
- Are historical events inevitable?
- What is the role of chance in historical knowledge?

## Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with a web of causes for a school rule change, historical event, or social movement. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

## Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...